

## Literary Analysis Essay of Song Lyrics

### COMPETENCY #1

### MLA FORMAT

Students will demonstrate their ability to analyze text by composing a literary analysis that summarizes a piece of text, analyzes its theme or message, evaluates the author's choices, and makes connections to the book's theme/ message.

- I can analyze text to determine author's use of craft in achieving his purpose **(competency 1)**
- I can draft an essay that analyzes author's craft and purpose and makes connections to the theme of leadership **(competency 1)**

#### **1st paragraph- Introduction**

Introduce your song in the essay by giving some historical background about it, including the title, songwriter, artist, year and any events or background that shaped its creation. Describing in this context would be a good way to introduce readers to the song and its theme of survival.

(**For example-** Bruce Springsteen is considered an American rock icon. He has entertained audiences for several years with his E Street Band. Springsteen, nicknamed "The Boss," has come to be one of the most successful recording artist since the late 80's and early 90's. He has written many songs that connect to the American experience, especially of the common, working class man. "**The Rising**" by Bruce Springsteen showcases the resiliency of Americans after the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001. The song served as a beacon of hope following the devastation experienced by our nation and felt across the globe. This emotional response that captured the sentiment of U.S. citizens was reflected in record breaking sales and propelled the song to the top of the record charts.)

#### **2<sup>nd</sup> Paragraph- Title**

Talk about the title. What is the title's objective? Why do you think it was chosen? Do you think it fits the song? Think of an alternative title for the song you selected. Explain how and why this song title would be suitable.

#### **3<sup>rd</sup> Paragraph- Theme**

What is the theme or overall message of the song? How important is the theme during the time period in which the song was written? Has the importance of the theme changed in today's world? Do you think the theme is important? Why? Quote a line(s) in the song that supports the theme? Use correct in-text citation.

#### **4<sup>th</sup> Paragraph- Analysis Connection**

What are the positive qualities/ aspects of the song? Explain how and why these qualities/aspects would attract an audience. What would draw an audience to the song? Are there any aspects of the song that could be considered negative that would offend or prevent listeners for enjoying the song?

#### **5<sup>th</sup> Paragraph- Analysis Devices**

Examine the literary devices and figurative language in the lyrics in the song. Examples may include similes, allusion, foreshadowing, hyperboles, and many others. Refer to the Figurative language review sheet. Quote 2 lines with Lit devices and/or Fig Lang. Use correct citation. What within the song lyrics do you find most interesting?

(**For example-** In "**The Sound of Silence**," Simon and Garfunkel use personification, which gives emotional characteristics to an object, animal or idea. By addressing the song to the "darkness" of nighttime, they emphasize the song's themes of loneliness and isolation. You can also write about the use of rhyme, repetition and other sound devices. In "**Bleeding Me**" by Metallica, the speaker uses repeated lines such as "I'm digging my way" (Hammett) and "This thorn in my side" (Hammett) to show his struggle in breaking away from addiction. )

#### **6<sup>th</sup> Paragraph- Music**

How does the music compliment the lyrics? Analyze the song's use of musical arrangements. Think about how the song's choice of a major or minor key, dominant instruments and texture relate to the lyrics and theme and create a specific mood. Is there a special beat or instrument that sticks out that adds to the story? Is the music fast, slow, or medium speed? Is it soft or loud? How does it change? Is the chorus tempo different than the verse? Why do you think they made these musical choices?

(**For example-** The minor piano chords and driving drumbeats of Adele's "**Set Fire to the Rain**" illustrate the speaker's misery after the end of a bitter relationship or in her song "**Rumor Has It**" , there is the strong, drum beat that mirrors the strong opinion expressed through the lyrics)

#### **7<sup>th</sup> Paragraph- Leadership Connection**

How does this song touch upon the theme of leadership? Quote a line from the song that helps to show this theme? Use correct in-text citation. Explain in detail. Remember, showing how there was lack of leadership is also a viable response

#### **8<sup>th</sup> Paragraph- Conclusion**

Sum up your thoughts about the song. What does it mean? Why is it important? What varied opinions were you able to find out about the song you chose? Were those opinions valuable or not? Explain. Connect the theme to your life or the world.

(**For example-** If you're writing about Christina Aguilera's "**Beautiful**," you might say that the song encourages people who have been bullied to recognize and celebrate their uniqueness rather than let people's words hurt them. Draw your paper together in a way that shows how the song's lyrical and musical elements illustrate this message. )

**MLA Format:** You should use the same format you have been using when writing essays in the past. Things for MLA: heading, header with page number, double space, 1 inch margins, centered title, 12 point font, Times Roman font, indentation.

**Grammar-** Your paper needs to be edited thoroughly using Spell and Grammar Check, as well as Self and Peer Editing

**Paper must be written in 3<sup>rd</sup> person.  
This means no use of I, me, you, we, or us.**